

Continuum

Diagram Recipes

When direction is up for debate.

PART 01

What & Why

4 slides

PART 02

How to Build

4 slides

PART 03

What to Expect

2 slides

What you'll learn.

What it is, how to build one, and what breaks it.

- 01

What & Why

What it is and when to use it.
- 02

How to Build

Three steps: name, draw, read.
- 03

What to Expect

What works and what breaks it.

3
SLIDES

3
SLIDES

2
SLIDES

Two directions. One line between them.

Put the team's opinions on one line. See the split instantly.

DO

Use when both directions are real options and you need to know where everyone stands before the argument starts.

DON'T

Don't use when one answer is already wrong. If the result is obvious, the diagram tells you nothing.

ALSO KNOWN AS

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Your team already has this tension.

IN A CHIP TEAM

Optimize

Add

Keep the architecture, or add a block? Both are real calls. Vote blind, then see where the team actually splits.

IN AN EV PROGRAM

Produce

Innovate

Ship the current design, or re-engineer for next gen? The gap between manager and engineers is the real risk number.

IN AUTOMOTIVE SALES

Service

Product

Lead with service contracts or hardware? If the team pitches inconsistently, customers feel it.

3 steps to build it.

Name both ends. Collect one vote at a time. Read where the team lands.

01

Name

Pick two competing options. Both must sound like real choices.

02

Draw

Everyone marks privately. No one sees results until all votes are in.

03

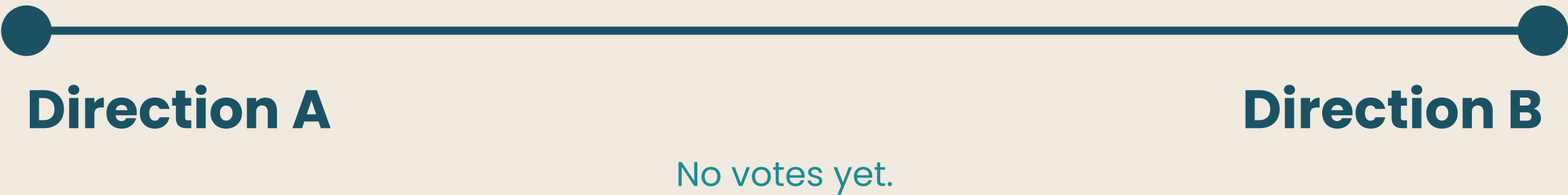
Read

Show all marks at once. The gap between clusters is what matters.

Step 1 — Name.

Pick two real options.

Both ends must sound like real choices. If one sounds wrong, rewrite it.



FOR EXAMPLE

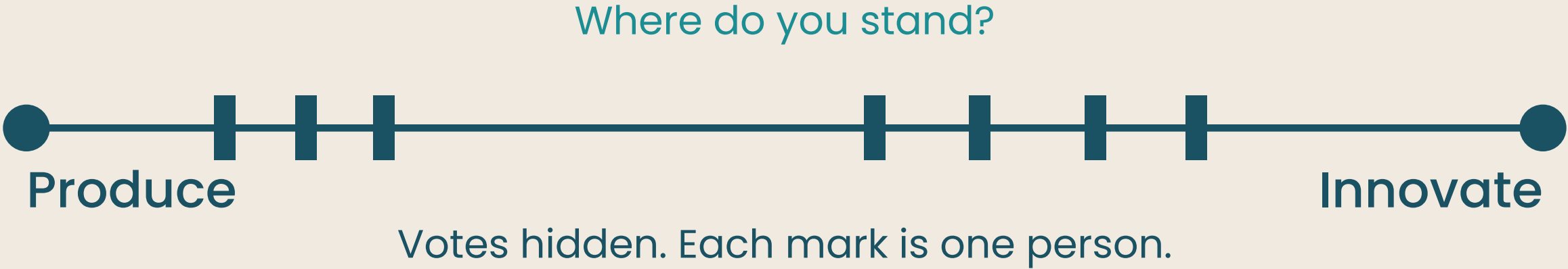
Optimize vs. Add
Acquire vs. Build

Produce vs. Innovate
Scale vs. Hone

Service vs. Product
Maintain vs. Improve

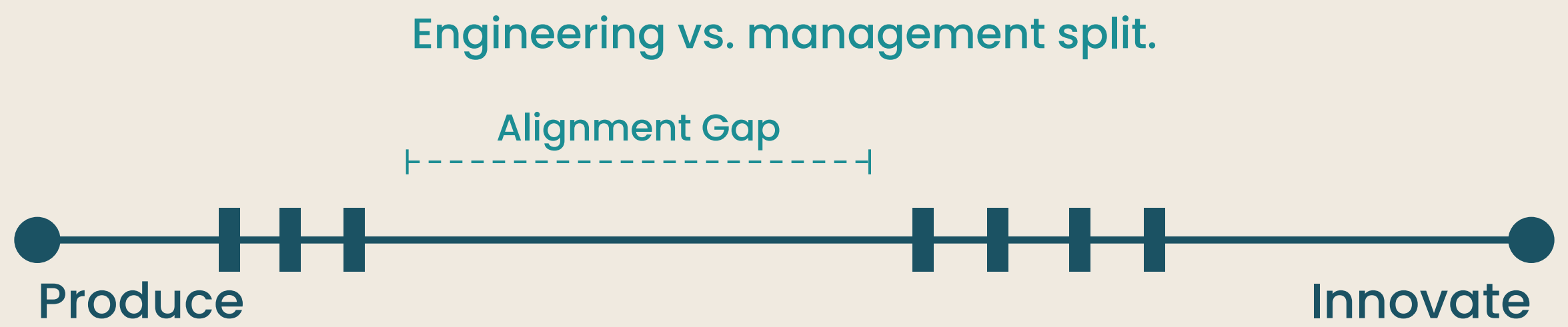
Step 2 — Draw. Gather votes, one at a time.

Everyone marks privately. If they see others first, they move toward the group.



Step 3 — Read. Name the gap.

Show all marks at once. Where the clusters land is the answer. Give it a name.



3 toward Produce. 4 toward Innovate. That gap is the next meeting.

Both ends must be real options.

If one end is wrong from the start, the vote is rigged. Rewrite until both are defensible.

DO

"Optimize vs. Add." Both are legitimate engineering calls. The line means something.

DON'T

"Innovate vs. Stay Stuck." Nobody picks Stay Stuck. You learn nothing.

FROM THE SOURCE

Each end should feel like a valid direction, not a trap.

Three inputs. One output.

Get these three right before you run it.

01 Two real options.

No genuine split, no useful data. If one answer is obvious, skip this.

02 Votes collected blind.

People anchor to the first answer they see. Collect all marks before showing results.

03 The gap is a starting point.

The diagram names where people stand. You still have to close the gap.

Three places to start.

Works anywhere the team has two real options and you need to see who stands where.

01 Technical direction

Build vs. buy. Optimize vs. add. Show where engineering, PM, and leadership actually land.

02 Team working agreements

Async vs. in-person. Spec-driven vs. exploratory. Useful for kickoffs and retros.

03 Sales and GTM alignment

Service vs. product pitch. If the team is split, the customer hears it.

Continuum.

STUCK? Diagrams Help.

This recipe is from STUCK? Diagrams Help., a guide to 12 diagrams every engineer and manager should know. Page 224.

ALSO KNOWN AS

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